

TOOTHPICK

Written by
Aran Davies

HUGH, 22, lanky, self-assertive, crammed into the backseat of a turbulent bus, one hand pressing a phone to his ear.

HUGH
(into phone)
MATE you as well? This is a sad
state of affairs this.

DON, 23, brash but lovable, loudest in the room, black hair, fusses with a piddly beard in his bedroom mirror, yelling into a phone on his bed.

DON
(into phone)
Broooo look look look right. This
guy calls me out of nowhere, saying
he got my number from Rose - the
weapon. Says he needs some extra
hands with this festival he's
running in a couple of months down
in Milton Keynes-

HUGH
(Interjects)
-Huh?

A rowdy bunch of yutes jeer from the front of the bus. Hugh sticks a finger in his other ear.

DON (CONT'D)
I can't just show up in sunnies
with a banging headache. Which I
will do. Because of you.

HUGH
(looks out the window)
I'm gonna ignore that. Also who the
fuck has an interview on a Sunday?

DON
I dunno mate but beggars *carn't* be
choosers. Can we not all do next
week instead?

HUGH
I'm already basically in town
aren't I? Honestly lad.

DON
(flicking through phone)
Yikes. Well didn't Lottie say her
mate was gonna tag along as well?
I..don't see anything on here from
her so maybe she'll rock up. Dunno.

HUGH (CONT'D)
Thoughts and prayers.

DON
I'll pay you back for the bus if it
makes you feel better.

HUGH (CONT'D)
You can pay me back in beers mate.
In a bit.

2 INT. BAR - EVENING

2

Hugh sits with a flat pint at a sticky table tucked into the fringe of the bar. It's surprisingly quiet for a Saturday. Across from him sits MAISIE (20, straight-shooter, arty), with a cold cider.

MAISIE
Clearly we need to get better
friends.

HUGH
You know I thought I had, this is
like, the refinement of the mates I
had back in uni.

MAISIE
That's rough.

A beat.

MAISIE (CONT'D)
Sorry, I mean-

HUGH
-No no no don't worry. To be honest
tonight was actually supposed to be
a big get together, we've not
really seen each other as a big
group since graduation, and even
that was split across summer and
winter.

MAISIE
Well that gives me something to
look forward to.

HUGH
Oh? You in third year?

MAISIE
Yeah-yeah, I'm studying graphics
design.

MAISIE (CONT'D)
(Snarkily)
Graphics design is my passion.

HUGH laughs, to be polite.

HUGH

At...

MAISIE

Ohhhh, uh I study at MMU. I met Lottie at a social for some student radio society I joined. That didn't last long. Kept swearing on the air. Did get some good promo in for my zine though.

HUGH takes a big glug of beer, masking him scanning the room.

MAISIE (CONT'D)

Thirsty mate?

HUGH

Parched mate parched. This is not our usual spot..not sure we picked this place. There's some decent bars I know in NQ.

MAISIE

God you're not an IPA wanker are you?

HUGH

I mean, I wouldn't say that. My friends would.

MAISIE

Right, you DO need better friends. Another one?

Hugh and Maisie laugh and chat through round after round.

3 INT. MAISIE'S FLAT - MORNING

3

Hugh's eyes creak open. Big mistake. Blue early morning light filters through green curtains.

He leans over the edge of Maisie's double bed, to find his and her phones plugged in to charge. There's a condom wrapper on the floor too. Thank god. He leans back to look at Maisie, sound asleep. She's cute.

He peels the covers off and nearly falls out of bed. He drapes his shirt over his chest, and goes to pull up his jeans. The belt buckle clinks. Maisie stirs.

MAISIE

...mmmm..Morning..

Maisie turns to see Hugh, mid-escape.

MAISIE (CONT'D)
..you're kidding right? You
couldn't even wait for me to wake
up? Fucking asshole.

Hugh frantically yanks his jeans up and fastens his belt.

HUGH
SORRY! SORRY! I didn't want to wake
you up. I was just gonna go sort my
headache out in your living room.

MAISIE
Aye I bet.

Hugh fumbles at the charger plugged into his phone. He
finally gets it out.

HUGH
Maisie..do you have any uhh
paracetamol or ibuprofen or
anything like that.

Maisie groans.

MAISIE
Ummm yeah there should be some in
the bathroom, can you get me two of
whatever you find please and uh put
the kettle on.

HUGH
Two secs.

4 INT. BATHROOM - EARLY MORNING

4

Hugh drinks straight from the cold tap, then splashes his
face with some water. A half-empty box of ibuprofen sits
above the sink, which he pockets.

5 INT. KITCHEN - EARLY MORNING

5

Maisie stands by a cafetière of coffee.

MAISIE
Black nectar mate. You got my
pills?

Hugh pops four out from the blister packaging and hands
Maisie two. Maisie pours two mugs of black coffee.

MAISIE (CONT'D)
Ta - if you want milk I've only got
oat milk.

Hugh holds up his pills.

HUGH
Bottoms up.

MAISIE
(miserably)
Cheers Hugh.

A beat.

HUGH
Look uh I feel grim abou-

MAISIE
-Yeah cheers man so do I.

HUGH
I mean about stepping out like
that. Can I buy you some breakfast?

She smiles, pottering around her kitchen.

MAISIE
Mate my fridge is barren you'd be
doing me a solid. Lottie cleared my
cupboards out when she was staying
here last week.

HUGH
(jeering, cockney)
Oi oi!

Maisie sticks two fingers up at him.

6 INT. CAFÉ - DAY

6

Hugh and Maisie sit in a booth. Hugh's finished his fry up, Maisie's still half-way through her oats.

MAISIE
God you're a fast eater. Couldn't
be me.

HUGH
I'm usually not but I felt like if
I didn't get something down me it'd
be..unpleasant.

MAISIE
You want another coffee? I'm gonna
get some juice.

HUGH
Yeah sure. Just gonna pop to the
loo for a sec.

Maisie puts her hand over his.

MAISIE
Be brave Hugh.

Hugh nods knowingly. He gets up, and we follow him through the café to a small bathroom.

7 INT. DINER BATHROOM - DAY

7

Hugh yanks his phone out and dials someone.

SPLITSCREEN:

Don's picks up the phone in his living room, turning down the drab show blaring on the telly.

DON
Hello sunshine! The man lives.

HUGH
Don I've gotten myself into a bit of a conundrum here.

DON
You sound like a pile of shit mate are you good?

HUGH
Uhh depends on your interpretation.

DON
MATE what have you done?

HUGH
I ended up staying out las-

DON
AYY good lad.

HUGH (CONT'D)
No Don, well, yes, uh.

DON
Good chat.

HUGH
No right listen. It ended up just being me and Lottie's mate Maisie last night.

DON
Tell me MORE mate tell me more.

HUGH
There's not much I can tell you, we ended up talking shite, I've spent god knows how much and I woke up in her bed.

DON

MY G! So what are you still at hers? Brave calling me there. What did I tell you I knew you had it in you-

HUGH

Nah man I'm in the loo of this café. She caught me trying to sneak out this morning and we've uh..

PAUSE SPLITSCREEN:

A CUSTOMER queues outside the bathroom door, listening to this strange conversation.

SPLITSCREEN CONT.:

DON

You what? Nah man.

HUGH

The long and short of it is we're getting breakfast.

DON

NAAAAAAAAAAAAH man what have you done to yourself.

HUGH

You what?

DON

You've not broken bread after breaking the bed have you?

Hugh laughs.

DON (CONT'D)

Nah right this is serious beans mate.

HUGH

Don, lad, you know I love you - but you are the last person I would ever take relationship advice from.

DON

OOO it's a relationship now?

HUGH

You know what I mean you cock.

DON

I'm a free bird mate, I'm soaring on cloud nine. You're spending your hard earned P on risky investments.

HUGH
You're an enigma pal.

Don sings the chorus of "Free Bird" down the phone. Hugh hangs up.

8 INT. VARIOUS - DAY/NIGHT

8

MONTAGE:

Hugh and Maisie continue to meet up over the next year. Sometimes the same bar, sometimes something new. Sometimes, they even get dinner. It usually ends the same way: sex, headache, ibuprofen, black coffee. Winter and Spring come and go.

Hugh shunts stage kit onto a truck in the middle of the night outside a venue. Maisie's clipping photos to a metal grid for her graduation show. Hugh's sat alone in a cheap hotel bar. Maisie's sat in a pub with her coursemates. He doesn't call.

It's nearly summer.

9 INT. HUGH'S FLAT - NIGHT

9

Dinner's in the slow cooker. Lo-fi hip-hop hums from the speaker in the corner. Hugh eyeballs his cards - him and Maisie are playing heads-up poker this time. A neat pile of three chips has been pushed into the centre of the table by Maisie.

A beat.

MAISIE
Like you wouldn't expect there to be so much faff around who sits facing the door, but then Adam starts kicking off in the group chat saying "this is childish, why aren't we just randomly allocating who goes where"...that went down like a sack of bricks.

Hugh pensively nods, looking at his cards, then the three face-down cards on the table.

MAISIE (CONT'D)
And like, we've been doing this for three years now why are people still getting so pressed over shit like this?

HUGH
Mmm.

MAISIE

We're all gonna have people looking at our work, public perception is not how we're marked..ugh people have too much free time. I can't stand it like. Are you gonna make a bet?

HUGH

Yes uhhhh sorry.

Hugh shunts four chips into the middle of the table.

MAISIE

Mate on the first round? Brave.

HUGH

I'm feeling lucky.

MAISIE

Yuck.

HUGH looks at three of the five face-down cards on the table being careful not to show Maisie, who's peering left and right.

MAISIE (CONT'D)

Sorry, I'm just trying to see what you've got.

HUGH

What, in the reflection of my eyes?? Bit despo.

Maisie tuts.

MAISIE

Rose says poker is all about paying attention.

HUGH

Coming from her that doesn't mean much.

Maisie jabs Hugh in the shin with her foot.

HUGH (CONT'D)

Fucking OW!

MAISIE

Nobody likes a hater, Hugh.

Maisie neatly plops another four chips on top of her bet.

MAISIE

Now stop being smug and crack on.

Hugh looks at his cards again, and adds another three chips to his bet.

MAISIE (CONT'D)

Noice.

Maisie lifts the fourth card of the flop, scanning Hugh for a reaction. He's deadpan.

HUGH

I never really understood the point of Poker.

MAISIE

I think pissing away your money is super great.

HUGH

Case in point right? Don was seeing this girl for a few weeks who wanted to go to the races in Chester. Absolute loon man. What sort of student has that kinda money?

MAISIE

(in received pronunciation)
The bank of mummy and daddy opens many a door, *Hugo*.

MAISIE (CONT'D)

I reckon the thrill of going home rich or totally ruining your life must even out somehow.

HUGH

God you'd hope, right?

All cards revealed: Maisie wins the round.

MAISIE

GWAAAAAN!

Maisie pulls her winnings in. Hugh reshuffles the cards.

HUGH

How's "Reflections" going?

Her face drops.

MAISIE

Huh? Hugh I finished it months ago. I had to do a whole viva about it.

HUGH

HUh?? That's mad. It still doesn't feel like 2023 to be honest.

MAISIE

..you sat up with me going through it the night before.

(MORE)

MAISIE (CONT'D)

I was pulling my hair out about the premise of whole series.

HUGH

You were fine though!

MAISIE

YES but only after I nearly puked from the stress of it.

HUGH

I had faith. Besides I was the one who told you to just go have a walk and come back to it an hour later. And you felt better after no?

MAISIE

That's literally not the point though? Like, it was a horrifically stressful time for me and I really just needed you to sit and listen.

HUGH

I did. I dealt with it for hours. With you.

MAISIE

Fucking excuse me?

Maisie stands and steps away from the table.

HUGH

I mean, I helped you deal with it. And that's fine, that's what I'm here for. As your partner.

MAISIE

I can't believe you.

HUGH

Huh??

MAISIE

Why can't you see the fucking forest for the trees Hugh? It's obvious - no matter what I'm dealing with it's like it fucking phases through you.

HUGH

Well that's just not true is it-

MAISIE

HUGH.

Maisie takes a moment.

MAISIE (CONT'D)

Hugh, what are we doing here? It's a Wednesday night. I've got mates of mine at the Anchor who I didn't go see to finally spend some time with ya-

HUGH

Well derig shifts are brutal, but you know I've not got a cushty student loan to sit on.

MAISIE

That's bullshit and you know it, I can barely make rent with it.

HUGH

Look all I'm saying is I've got my own issues and life, and you have yours. Your issues are your problem. Not mine. And that's okay!

Maisie's shoulder loosen.

MAISIE

(tearfully)

You're an asshole.

Maisie grabs her coat and keys, and slams the door behind her. Hugh remains at the table. The slow cooker beeps.

10

INT. THE GOOSE AND GANDER - NIGHT

10

Hugh, Don and ROSE (21, chic, always has a mad story to tell) sit around a round table. Hugh's slumped forward, staring down the bottom of his glass.

ROSE

You brought that on yourself mate.

DON

I dunno, it's a tricky one.

ROSE

It isn't though is it. Why are lads like this it drives me up the fuckin' wall.

Rose swirls the remains of her pint of ale.

HUGH

Sorry have I missed something here?

Don closes his eyes, bracing.

DON

Don't-

ROSE
Aye you have. Why do you think
she's so upset?

She throws an open palm up.

ROSE (CONT'D)
Actually, don't say anything. God
this is just like that time Lottie
broke up with her fella.

DON
Well, that was Nathan's fault to be
fair. Calling a nearly 1 year
relationship a "situationship" is
crazy work.

Rose's eyes widen.

ROSE
Since when were you so tactful?

HUGH
I just don't see how I could've
done anything differently..like I
listened and-

ROSE
Oh sick the bare minimum? No
wayyyyyyy.

DON
Hugh mate, where to start...for
one, you should've nodded and said
"yes, yes"

Rose thumps him in the arm.

ROSE
Not fucking helping Donovan.

DON
(snarkily)
I've got wisdom to impart to the
youth of today Rose. I'm spinning a
lot of plates, and need I remind
you whilst managing a very
demanding career in stage
management.

Hugh leans back in his chair.

ROSE
First off I wouldn't go around
bragging about the group of first
and second years you've been
shagging Don.

HUGH
Bit noncey.

DON
Some die of thirst while others
drown.

Hugh winces.

ROSE
Also if we're supposed to be paid
as stage managers that'd be fucking
grand, but I think that's punching
up a lot from promoter.

That shut him up.

Another round of beers follows. The pub's dead.

ROSE (CONT'D)
Say you'd come back from a show in
the early morning Hugh, and ended
up being too tired to do sommet
with Maisie the next day.

HUGH
Well I'd just get on with it? No? I
can't make that her problem..

Rose massages her temples.

ROSE
Mate that's it though?

Don passively nods.

HUGH
Can either of you be straight with
me on this I feel like I'm fucking
mental here.

ROSE
You aren't beating male stereotypes
Hugh. It's dire.

The bell rings for last orders. The gang neck the rest of
their pints.

ROSE
Look mate you either get it or you
don't, I'm not your mum. Just think
about it?

HUGH
God that's a horrid thought.

ROSE
What, some introspection?

HUGH
No, you being my mum.

ROSE
Mate I'd have thrown myself down
the stairs.

DON
DAMN.

They chuckle.

HUGH
I'm not even sure what I'm supposed
to be thinking about but..yeah. Ok.

DON
Said like a true man.

ROSE
Mate you're waffling.

DON
We should get a shift one, they're
closing. Another one?

Hugh and Rose look at each other knowingly.

11 **EXT. CLUB - NIGHT**

11

Hugh stands with his back to a brick wall. Hard techno booms from a basement venue behind him. The city rumbles. He fumbles for a straight from his jacket pocket. Six pints was a shit idea.

WOMAN
Hii, can I bum a fag?

A young woman, draped in a pale green cardigan with crazy earrings slides next to Hugh.

HUGH
Yeah, 'course. Hang on..

Hugh struggles to pull another cig from his jacket.

WOMAN
You alright there?

HUGH
Hahahaha yeah sorry I'm just..

He pulls out a slightly crumpled cig and hands it to the woman, along with a lighter.

WOMAN
Ah thanks, I'm sorted there.

She flashes a clipper lighter and lights the cig, taking a deep first breath, exhaling through her teeth. Hugh struggles to get his lighter working.

WOMAN (CONT'D)

Do you wanna borrow mine?

HUGH

Oh man thank you. I'm embarrassing myself here.

The woman laughs.

WOMAN

You're good pal you're good. I'm Minty.

HUGH

Good to meet you.

A beat.

MINTY

Have you come here with anyone or?

HUGH

Allegedly yes, I think I last saw my mate dash into the loos. The other one's over there.

HUGH points..

WHIP PAN TO:

Rose chats up a bouncer, twirling her hair with a finger. She nods her head at Hugh.

MINTY

Go on lass.

HUGH

What about you?

MINTY

Oh I came to see Signal. They've just come back from a long tour across Europe and I'm not paid enough to afford the travel there so as soon I saw on Insta that they were in town I was ON it.

HUGH

Aren't there some decent cheap coaches to like, the Netherlands or Germany?

MINTY

Yeah but they're LONG.
(MORE)

MINTY (CONT'D)
Imagine being sat next to some neek
for thirteen hours.

HUGH
I hate to tell you this, but you're
stood next to one RIGHT now.

MINTY
Shit you're letting the team
down..uhh..

HUGH
Hugh. Shit I didn't tell you my
name earlier did I?

MINTY
That's two strikes now.

She smiles. Hugh mirrors her, albeit awkwardly.

MINTY (CONT'D)
Come on, you can make it up to me
by letting me get you a drink.

HUGH
If I must.

They both step into the venue. The music gets heavier and
heavier, until...

SMASH CUT TO:

12 INT. MINTY'S FLAT - MORNING

12

Windchimes clink as a gentle breeze passes through Minty's
apartment. Hugh stirs, wiping his face with his hands. He
stumbles into the living room, dressed. Minty leans over the
balcony bars attached to floor-to-ceiling windows, tapping a
fag over the edge. She half looks over her shoulder.

MINTY
(cheerily)
Morning you.

HUGH
Mmmmmorning.

A collection of curated trinkets and art prints line Minty's
apartment. A stick on incense burns on a tabletop.

MINTY
If you need a coffee there's only
instant. Feeling okay sweetheart?

HUGH
I have been worse.

MINTY

I find that hard to believe, you were certainly enthusiastic last night.

HUGH

Oh yeah?

He walks up to Minty, and leans in to hug her. Before he can reach her, she turns.

MINTY

Come on, kettle's getting cold. I've got some bits I need to go get from town as well before Market Street goes to shit.

Minty grabs the instant coffee and a mug from a cupboard and pops it by the kettle.

HUGH

Oh? What're you getting?

MINTY

Stuff from Boots. I've ran out of salicylic acid.

HUGH

If you want, I know a sick café in the arcade nearby...

MINTY

Hugh, that's kind of you but I'm alright. Last night was fun, and I appreciate you not just bailing in the middle of the night, but you need to get home.

13 INT. VARIOUS - DAY/NIGHT

13

The cycle repeats. Hugh sits with different women in different bars, some inside, some outdoors. Sometimes breakfast, sometimes not. As time goes on, he looks more and more checked out.

14 INT. THE GOOSE AND GANDER - DAY

14

Hugh sits at a table with Rose and Don, each with a drink in hand. Hugh has a "Birthday Boy" badge pinned to his jumper. Three glasses are stacked to the side of the table.

DON

So that's when this Greek unit of a man picks up this guy and drags him out of the welfare tent. Turns out he was so off his face he thought he was plundering treasure.

ROSE

Things that never happened.

DON

You believe what you want man but the things I see at festivals is fucking crazy. Keeps it interesting.

ROSE

I didn't have the energy for it man too many weirdos and I could barely catch the sets I wanted to see.

HUGH

Well you're working. Honestly I go back to the hotel and nap as much as I can now before derigs. Chatting shit mid-show is never worth it.

DON

I would get such FOMO.

HUGH

You can come help me lug staging onto the van next Tuesday then.

DON

Hard pass mate. I'd end up like you.

HUGH

What's that supposed to mean sorry?

DON

We're worried about you lad. You uhh..

Don looks to Rose.

ROSE

Nice one Don. Hugh mate have you been feeling alright?

HUGH

(resolutely)

Yeah I'm class.

DON

You sure? I've been trying to get you on sound for Aciid for the past month and you never pick up the phone in the evenings! It's fucking my admin up.

ROSE

How've you made this about your bloody club night? Mentaaaal.

DON

Nah nah not like that, it's...

HUGH

I'm fine guys.

ROSE

Hugh, fine isn't blowing all your wages on getting fucked and getting fucked up.

DON

Bars.

Don tenses up his shoulders and sinks his neck into his chest. Rose slaps him over the back of the head.

DON (CONT'D)

Yeah. Fair.

HUGH

It's been a crazy season. Lot's of back to back days, I've barely been home.

ROSE

Well, that's not what I've heard. My bouncer mate says he's seen you out on town most Fridays, with random lasses.

DON

Whenever I see you man you're drained. Always. And you're sick at sound, plus you love it...

HUGH

Crew work pays man.

ROSE

Hugh you aren't seeing the bigger picture here. You're in this loop of blowing all your money on getting laid-

HUGH

But I think-

ROSE (CONT'D)

-then busting your ass all the time taking every shitty shift you can get, so you get so tired you want to drink more. Samsara or whatever. *Is it samsara?*

DON

Samsahara? Samantha?

ROSE

Sod this, you do it Don.

DON

Mate women are a distraction. You need to stop obsessing with them, and focus on the most important thing: your work.

ROSE

I'm surrounded by fucking goblins I swear to god.

HUGH

Guys I hear you. I do. It's uh-

Memories of Hugh and Maisie flicker through Hugh's mind.

HUGH (CONT'D)

I feel like the last two years have slipped through my hands. The time we spend together is the only time I ever really feel like I'm here, or that shit has...meaning?

Don scoots his chair round to Hugh and puts his arm around his shoulder.

HUGH (CONT'D)

This is stupid, why am I being like this hahahah.

ROSE

No mate please, carry on.

HUGH

I think I need to change my approach here. I've been wasting my time chasing other women, and wasting their time probably as well?

ROSE

Well, they had just as much choice in these situations.

DON

Very true.

HUGH

Yeah I suppose. Something needs to change. I'll figure it out. Cheers guys.

They embrace.

ROSE

Right then. MORE BEER!

All three cheer. Like cavemen.

15 INT. HUGH'S FLAT - DAY

15

Hugh slumps on the sofa, lazily rotating a Wii remote around like a sword. A knock at the door.

MAISIE (O.S.)
(muffled by the door)
Hugh?

Hugh freezes.

Maisie knocks again. He leaps up, quickly checks himself out in the mirror, scruffs with his hair.

MAISIE (CONT'D)
Mate I know you're in there, I can
hear your telly. Come on.

Hugh opens the door, double-taking. Maisie's changed her hair. New colour of lipstick maybe?

HUGH
Hi.

MAISIE
Hey. I uhh, was walking into town
and realised I was going past your
place. Figured now would be as good
a time as any to see if you're
still alive?

HUGH
It's..good to see you Maisie. Do
you wanna come in for a brew?

MAISIE
Oh that'd be ace.

They sit on opposite sides of the sofa. A kit-cat clock ticks on the wall between them. Hugh sips his coffee. Maisie twirls the teabag in her brew.

MAISIE (CONT'D)
How have you still not decorated
your gaff?

HUGH
I've just..not thought about it.
Been busy.

MAISIE
Nothing's changed there.

The clock ticks.

HUGH

How's work? I would've thought you'd have gone home after graduation.

MAISIE

I dunno Hugh. After we split everything sort of went to pot for a couple of weeks. My degree show ironed itself out, but it took a good few weeks at mum's to turn myself around.

HUGH

Sorry.

MAISIE

Hugh it was nothing to do with you. Everything got a bit much. I was sleeping like shit, I couldn't eat properly, all my mates were on like a knife edge.

A beat.

HUGH

A-

MAISIE

But ummm work's good. It's great actually. I'm working at a design agency near Spinningfields. Proper posh place, but everyone's super lovely. My missus works nearby as well so we walk there together. I love it.

Hugh's eyes widen.

HUGH

Oh! You're seeing someone?

MAISIE

Yeah, Alice is just really sweet. She's in marketing, something about data analytics. Absolutely not for me but I do try to listen to her talk about it.

HUGH

Does sound dreary though.

MAISIE

Well she loves it! And that's all I can hope for her. Are you still crewing?

HUGH

Yeah..I'm making rent and then some but I'm..I dunno. Sorry Maisie this is a bit of an odd time for a catchup for me.

MAISIE

Oh..do you want me to leave?

HUGH

No! No. I..I need some air. Mind if we walk and talk?

16 **EXT. PARK - DAY**

16

Hugh and Maisie amble down a leafy park path.

MAISIE

It's mainly print work at the moment, we're doing a lot of flyers for events around the city.

HUGH

I didn't think there was that much going on.

MAISIE

Well you would say that wouldn't you?

HUGH

Working this much doesn't help. Manchester's a big place as well, where am I supposed to find out about this stuff?

MAISIE

Mate you're in Manchester stick your neck out the window and you'll hear about something. Hugh you are not the only person who works. The whole benefit of freelancing is taking the time off to relax.

A bird flies overhead.

HUGH

Work to live not live to work.

MAISIE

Exactly. You're burning your candle at both ends mate. It's why..well it's why you look like shit.

HUGH

That helps.

MAISIE

Did you expect pity? Hugh the world is not going to stop for you. My world did not stop for you. Don's wouldn't. Rose's wouldn't.

HUGH

I'm not wanting pity, I just-

Maisie steps out in front of Hugh.

MAISIE

I don't actually believe that you know what you want Hugh. Maybe that's unfair, I haven't spoken to you in time. But get in the driver's seat of your own life.

Hugh and Maisie talk from a distance. They hug. Hugh sinks his head into her shoulder.

17

EXT. PARK - LATE AFTERNOON

17

Hugh and Maisie sit on a park bench. The autumn sun dips behind the trees.

MAISIE

I look back on that naive teenager moving here for university expecting my whole world to expand. Mum always banged on about it.

HUGH

So COVID really buggered you there didn't it.

MAISIE

Lad. Biting the pillow. It was horrible.

HUGH

Minging housemates didn't help either.

MAISIE

Well you were an improvement in that regard. My world has grown so much over the last year. Every year I try and guess how the next will go, and I'm never right. Ever.

HUGH

I am.

MAISIE

And are you happy?

Hugh looks through her.

MAISIE (CONT'D)

It will get better Hugh, but only when you realise that you can't plug these gaps in yourself with other people. You need to spend time on your own. Really on your own.

HUGH

But sex is great.

MAISIE

You know what's even better? Having sex with someone who actually respects you, and knows you.

HUGH

I don't really know what to say.

MAISIE

Then say nothing. Think on it. Anyway I'm freezing mi chebs off.

They both stand, looking towards each other.

HUGH

Look after yourself Maisie.

MAISIE

You too mate.

They hug. Maisie kisses him on the cheek. Hugh looks into the distance behind her.

18 INT. THE GOOSE AND GANDER - NIGHT

18

A few months have passed. Hugh sits in a t-shirt and chinos. Rose mingles at the bar. A cottage-core girl is sat at a table with some friends across from her, nattering away. Their eyes meet. Hugh wipes the beer froth from his moustache haphazardly. She frowns to hide a laugh. Her mates leave for a cig, and she gestures him over.

Hugh looks to Rose and looks to the cottage-core girl. He looks down the camera.

CUT TO BLACK.